

world, especially his wife and two sons back in Delhi. His father, S.P. Bagla, a deeply spiritual 75-year-old retired IAS officer, was philosophical. "God will be with you. He will protect you." This was also the gist of over 800 messages of encouragement that blinked on his phones for nearly 40 hours. Friends and family kept round-the-clock vigils for him near the hotel. In the darkened room, the duo spoke in whispers about their families and what they could have done to prepare them for such eventualities. Outside, the turmoil continued. On Friday afternoon, the firing reached a crescendo and then stopped. Moments later, five energetic young Black Cat commandos were escorting them to safety past the detritus in the hotel.

Now, sitting atop another five-star hotel, in the heart of Delhi, Bagla is contemplative. The twinkle in his eyes has turned into a faraway gaze. The import of the event evidently goes far deeper than instinctively checking the exits of every hotel before he checks in. "It was therapeutic and made me realise the importance of friends and family. Over the years, we tend to pick up a lot of negativity which clutters the brain. But an experience like this brings us back to basics and refocuses you. I am now more resolute to do something for people. I have become simpler, more relaxed and more at peace with myself," he says.

by Sandeep Unnithan

WHEN OPTIMISM BEATS TRAGEDY

RANSLEY SANTHAMAYOR, 29

WHAT HAPPENED: Was shot at Café Leopold

A pleasant beginning to his day could hardly have warned Ransley Santhamayar, 29, about the disaster that awaited him. A product manager at a telecom company, Ransley was at Colaba's Café Leopold—a popular spot with Indians and backpackers alike—with a friend when he got the news of his promotion in the evening. They decided to stay for a drink in celebration of his achievement. They had just been seated and were waiting for another friend when they saw a grim-faced boy run around the restaurant randomly spraying bullets. "After the first round of firing, the terrorist came back to check if anyone had survived. I was hiding under the table and he saw my leg moving. I saw him aim his gun at me and shoot at my leg," he says. Ransley was rushed to the Bombay Hospital as soon as the terrorists fled.

Lying on a bed for weeks with severe bullet injuries on his right leg, he took inspiration from an American athlete who too had been shot at during the attack. The woman, whose life depended on sports, had been shot in

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both her legs and the doctors said it was unlikely that she'd ever be as active again. "I had just been operated upon. When I opened my eyes, I saw this woman who despite her immense loss, was smiling and praying that Ajmal Kasab transforms himself," says Ransley.

The past year has seen Ransley undergoing seven crucial surgeries. But even today, he cannot walk without crutches and fixators (a metal rod that prevents his bone from collapsing). And though doctors have told him that an inch of his leg may be amputated in the next surgery, Ransley shows no signs of grief. His injured leg tells the tale of trauma but his face is full of optimism and enthusiasm. His cheerful demeanour gives no indication of his painful past. He says he hasn't let the physical agony affect his mind. "I try and do everything the way I used to earlier. I go to work and meet friends regularly. I can't party late at night the way I used to but never miss a chance to catch the latest movie," he says.

The one thing that has changed dramatically is his family's concern. "They'll run from another room to give me a glass of water even if I'm standing right next to the fridge. That never happened earlier," he laughs. But the incident has wrought one change in him: it has made him more responsible as a son. "My father would stand shellshocked every time I was wheeled into the ICU at the Bombay Hospital for yet another operation," he says. A retired professional, Ransley's father Gilbert Santhamayar never left his son's side for the two months